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Markey appears to ignore Moulton's run

Senator barely mentions challenger in public, but in private he's competing

By Sam Brodey
and James Pindell
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — On the surface, it looked like just another day on the job for Senator Ed Markey.

On Nov. 26, Markey spoke at a weekly gathering of progressive protesters outside the Immigration and Customs Enforcement office in Burlington, Mass., praising their mission to draw attention to the Trump administration's deportation policy.

But the unremarkable scene ob-

scured a messier behind-the-scenes power struggle that illustrates an emerging reality of the 2026 Senate race in Massachusetts.

Publicly, Markey is hardly acknowledging his primary challenger, Representative Seth Moulton of Salem, as any sort of threat. But privately, he's acting like a seasoned political competitor.

Like Markey, Moulton had also made plans to speak at the anti-ICE demonstration that week in Burlington, which sits in the congress-

man's district.

But Markey's team issued an ultimatum to the organizers: He would not appear at the event if Moulton was there. Informed of Markey's demand, Moulton ultimately decided to withdraw; the senator was the sole "keynote" speaker at the gathering, with his remarks later posted to social media.

The fuss stemmed in part from a misunderstanding. Both Moulton's and Markey's teams were told ahead of time by different people that the speaking slot on Nov. 26 was open. Markey's staff had actually committed the morning of Nov.

24 that he would go, according to one source close to the protest organizers, and when Moulton's team began finalizing plans, other organizers told them the slot was not up for grabs after all.

The senator did not want to appear alongside Moulton at the event so as to not distract from the advocates' focus on Trump's immigration policy, according to a source close to the senator.

Ultimately, Markey had boxed Moulton out of an event in his own district. Nearly five months later, Moulton hasn't yet spoken at the protest.

MARKEY, Page A6

Mass. leaders brace for scrutiny

White House turns focus to benefit fraud, with an eye on states led by Democrats

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Massachusetts elected officials are once again on high alert. Conflicts with the Trump administration, after all, have become an exercise of muscle memory.

There have been scraps over immigration, higher education, and energy, among many others. The likely next frontier: government benefit fraud.

During his State of the Union speech in February, President Trump listed Massachusetts among the Democrat-led states he alleges are rife with fraud.

"This is the kind of corruption that shreds the fabric of a nation, and we are working on it like you wouldn't believe," Trump said before declaring that Vice President JD Vance would lead a "war on fraud" — an operation the president promised would recoup so much money "we will actually have a balanced budget overnight."

At a press conference a few days later, Vance said the administration would pause \$250 million in Medicaid funding to Minnesota — another state Trump cited in the speech — in response to widespread welfare fraud found there. Minnesota's attorney general, Keith Ellison, then sued the federal

FRAUD, Page A6



PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

'Really hitting our schools hard'

By Mariana Simões
GLOBE STAFF

Amanda Crowley's heart sinks every time she drops off Hunter, her lively 11-year-old son with special needs, at Williams Intermediate School in Bridgewater.

The special education teacher assigned to his class was lost to budget cuts last spring, and a new instructor with the proper license has yet to step in.

Hunter has autism and a rare genetic condition known as Rubinstein-Taybi syndrome, which legally entitles him to a qualified teacher. Without one, the fifth-grader, who is working on a kindergarten level, is "not making any academic progress," Crowley said.

Special education teachers are leaving classrooms, jeopardizing learning for students in need



Hunter, top with sister Ava and above doing a craft, is entitled to a qualified special education teacher.

Budget cuts and challenging working conditions are driving special education teachers out of schools at alarming rates. Turnover is so high in Massachusetts that one out of every three instructors leaves their classroom each year, according to data collected by the Special Education Workforce Research Collaborative, a federally funded initiative based in Arlington, Va.

That constant churn destabilizes learning for the most vulnerable students and comes as the number of kids with special needs is steadily increasing across the state.

In 2020, students with disabilities made up 18 percent of the public school population.

TEACHERS, Page A7

City seeks limit on workers' GLP-1 coverage

Officials predict 'massive' impact without change

By Niki Griswold
GLOBE STAFF

Mayor Michelle Wu's administration said Monday it is seeking to limit coverage of GLP-1 weight loss medications for city employees amid what it called skyrocketing health insurance costs, warning that without changes, the city and its workers will face "massive and immediate" consequences.

The city raised the alarm bell as it stares down an already tightening budget, for which Wu has told department heads to prepare for potential cuts.

Private insurers and state officials here and elsewhere have already taken their own steps to scale back coverage for a popular class of prescription drugs for weight loss, citing soaring costs.

Ashley Groffenberger, the city's chief financial officer, sent a letter to the City Council on Monday, saying health insurance rates for city employees are poised to spike by nearly 23 percent in the fiscal year that starts in July — the highest year-over-year increase in premium costs the city has seen "in recent history." Boston included \$483 million for all health-related benefits for employees and retirees in its budget for this fiscal year,

GLP-1, Page A7



Run of the chill

Tuesday: Early shower, cooler. High: 47-52. Low: 25-30.

Wednesday: Colder, some sun. High: 35-40. Low: 28-33.

High tide: 10:48 a.m. 11:14 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:53 Sunset: 6:53

Comics and Weather, **D5-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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A US district court in Massachusetts blocked the government from implementing a series of decisions on vaccines made over the last year by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. A5.

A Tyngsborough man is facing a murder charge after human remains, likely those of a missing woman, were found buried under the floor of a garage. **B1.**

President Trump disparaged US allies that had responded coolly to, or outright rebuffed, his call to send warships to escort merchant vessels in and out of the Persian Gulf. **A4.**

A St. Patrick's Day foreclosure auction for six acres on a key stretch of Dorchester Avenue in South Boston can proceed as scheduled, two judges ruled despite a flurry of last-minute legal filings. **D1.**

As more seniors use pot, more doctors worry

Many turn to cannabis for pain, sleep issues but health risks arise

By Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

When 71-year-old Roberta Brodin had a slip and fall during February's monster blizzard, it was marijuana that picked her back up.

The retired Quincy native, who also suffered a stroke in January, said she rarely takes various sedatives and pain pills prescribed to her. Instead, she prefers taking 40 to 50 milligrams of cannabis edibles, tinctures, and flower per day, after getting her medical marijuana card through a telehealth company.

"It's calmed me down when I've started getting real shaky," Brodin said.

Brodin isn't alone. For much of the last

CANNABIS, Page A10



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Roberta Brodin, 71, toured the grow house at Thrive Dispensary in Quincy.